EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Did God Harden Pharaoh's Heart? Eight Keys to Free Will

Given Monday 16 December 2024 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 4:6

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 4 (Free Will), Chapter 6, completing the essay

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 16 December 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Fourth Essay So Far

This was the last shiur of the autumn term, held at a different time from usual, and it completed the fourth essay. (The Rabbi's Thursday night shiurim on the laws of Chanukah in the Shulchan Aruch would be finished the following Monday at the usual time, so that the community could come to Chanukah having learnt them. Essay 5 would begin in January.)

The Rabbi reviewed the essay:

- **Chapters 1 and 2:** for Saadia, the earth is the pinnacle of creation and humans are the pinnacle of the earth, so the entire universe was created for humanity. The **Ibn Ezra** and the **Rambam** disagreed.
- **Chapter 3:** Saadia's very strict understanding of *bechirah*. Choice comes **before** the act, not simultaneously with it. It includes **abstaining** from an action. And it covers acting **inadvertently**, as distinct from acting with no knowledge at all, which is not an action from the Torah's point of view.
- **Chapter 4:** proofs that we have free will from the **senses**, from **reason**, from **Scripture** and from **tradition** (the Gemara), and the famous question of how Hashem's full foreknowledge fits with our free will.
- **Chapter 5:** seven questions on free will: why command the righteous; why send prophets to the wicked; who is responsible when someone carries out what was decreed; **David and Avshalom**; **Sancheriv and Nevuchadnezzar**; and why humans sometimes have to lie.

The plan for Chapter 6

In the final chapter Saadia gives **eight categories** of verses in Tanach that seem to contradict *bechirah*. Both at the beginning and at the end he tells us: **I am giving you the keys** (*petachim*). There are many such verses; whenever you meet one that seems to show Hashem taking away free will, apply one of these keys.

His opening principle: most of these apparent contradictions come from **not using language broadly**. "If you're not willing to be liberal with the use of language, you're going to be very

limited in your understanding of language." You have to be willing to understand things in a broader sense than the exact words.

Category 1: A Warning, Not a Prevention

There is a big difference between Hashem **warning** you not to do something and Hashem **preventing** you.

When Avimelech took Sarah (read in shul a few weeks earlier), Hashem told him in a dream at night: **ואחשך גם אנכי אותך מחטוא לי**, "I also withheld you from sinning against Me." People think Hashem intervened and stopped Avimelech from exercising his free will. Saadia: that is the wrong way to understand the story. It means **I withheld you by warning you**: I told you not to do this, and that you would be punished if you did.

The same use of "cannot" appears in the Torah:

> **לא יוכל בעלה הראשון אשר שלחה לשוב לקחתה**: a man may remarry his divorcee (indeed there is a mitzvah to do so), but if she married someone else in between, "her first husband *cannot* take her back." If he wanted to, he could. "Cannot" means he has been commanded not to.
>
> **לא תוכל לזבוח את הפסח**: you *cannot* slaughter the Pesach" outside Yerushalayim. "Of course" I'm able to do so if I want to."

So when Hashem told Avimelech "I withheld you," it means I warned you, and you decided not to, "which was the right thing. But it was completely your choice."

As the Rabbi said last time, **Rashi**, the **Radak** and the vast majority of the Rishonim read the story simply: Hashem struck Avimelech with an illness at night that physically prevented him. Those Rishonim must say that there are **extreme instances** when Hashem intervenes to prevent a person being violated, even though normally there is free will. "But as we have seen over and over through this essay, Saadia takes a very sharp line… Free will is complete. You can do whatever you want." So Saadia prefers to read the words broadly.

Category 2: Hashem Takes Away Physical Benefits

The second category: Hashem takes away **something physical** from a person, and people mistake it for Hashem taking away his free will.

The verse

השמן לב העם הזה ואזניו הכבד ועיניו השע (Yeshayahu 6:10)

The *heh* can be read two ways:

- as an **instruction**: "Make the heart of this people fat, make their ears heavy, and shut their eyes," lest they repent;
- or as a **description of the past**: "The heart of this people has grown fat, their ears heavy."

Three readings

	How the verse reads	Is free will a problem?
Rashi	A description of the past. **The people hardened their own hearts** and closed their ears, because they knew that if they listened they would have to do teshuvah, and they did not want to	No. It is a historical fact about their own choice
The Rambam	Hashem says He will harden their hearts. Not that He makes them sin, but that **He takes away the gift of teshuvah** from people who have sunk so far into darkness that they are no longer fit for it	Hashem does sometimes withhold teshuvah, as with Pharaoh
Saadia	Hashem will bring upon them **physical, mundane troubles**, loss of money, war, "whatever it may be," that **preoccupy and confuse them**, so that they cannot pay attention to mending their ways, "confused like a blind man at noon"	No. Teshuvah becomes harder, but "if you really focus and push yourself, you can"

Rashi's reading, the Rabbi illustrated: "Sometimes a person knows that if he goes to a certain shiur, a certain Shabbaton, he's going to do teshuvah. But he doesn't want to. So he says, okay, I'm not going to go. He hardens his heart."

The Rambam, the Rabbi noted, quotes this verse as one of the key sources for a principle the class has discussed many times, on Mondays and on Tuesdays, and which they saw when they learnt **Shemonah Perakim**: a person or a nation can descend so far that Hashem **takes away the ability to do teshuvah**, so that they receive the consequences of their actions.

Saadia does not accept that. "A person has strict free will, complete free will. So it can't be that the pasuk is saying, I'm going to take away your ability to do teshuvah." What it means is: I am going to confuse them and take away their tranquillity of mind. "Of course, if you choose and you persist and you overcome these challenges, of course you can do teshuvah."

Category 3: Strengthening the Heart (Pharaoh and Sichon)

"The third one is really quite astonishing, and he is unique. I think he's the only one who offers this interpretation."

The famous question

ויחזק ה' את לב פרעה: Hashem strengthened Pharaoh's heart. Saadia himself concedes that the verse says "the heart of Pharaoh." It seems Hashem strengthened his resolve and prevented him from doing the right thing. How can that be?

Saadia's answer

It does not mean that Hashem hardened his resolve not to release the people. "Nothing to do with that, because a person has full free will." It means that Hashem **gave Pharaoh the life and the physical strength to withstand the plagues**. There was hail, there was pestilence; he could have died in any of them. Hashem kept him alive, because He wanted the whole drama to continue to the Red Sea, as the verse says, to show Pharaoh His power: **בעבור הראתך את כחי**, "for this I have kept you standing, to show you My strength."

The same applies to **Sichon**: **כי הקשה ה' אלהיך את רוחו ואמץ את לבבו**. What plague threatened Sichon? Saadia: when he heard that Bnei Yisrael were coming he might have had **a heart attack**, lost his physical capacity, and been unable to make a conscious choice. Hashem strengthened his heart so that he would not die of fear. Then, with free choice, he chose not to let the Jewish people pass through his land. Saadia brings verses showing that people sometimes die of fear, as when hearts "melted."

Richard asked: why then does the verse speak of strengthening his *heart*? "Good question." Saadia himself addresses it. *Lev* here must be understood broadly, as the *nefesh*, the life force: when something terrible happens, Hashem gives you the ability to get through it. "If we're honest, it's not what the pasuk says really... Be broad, be liberal with the words." This is why, the Rabbi said, Saadia's approach is rarely mentioned when people discuss Pharaoh's free will. "Difficult, I know. It is very difficult."

The other approaches

The Rabbi set out the classical alternatives:

1. **The Rambam** (consistent with the principle above): Pharaoh chose wrongly by his own free will in the first five plagues. In the last five, Hashem took away his ability to do teshuvah, so that he would suffer the consequences of his choices.
2. **The Ramban on Shemot chapter 7** asks the question everyone asks: if Hashem hardened his heart, what was his sin? He gives **two explanations, both true**:
3. Pharaoh's wickedness, the great evils he had done to Israel without cause, meant that justice required **the ways of repentance be withheld from him** (the Midrash's approach, like the Rambam).
4. In the later plagues, Pharaoh would have released them **only because he could not bear the plagues**, not to do the will of his Creator. So Hashem strengthened his heart.

The Rabbi explained the Ramban's second answer: the hand of God was so apparent that releasing the people at plague six would not have been a free choice. "It's like Hashem putting a gun to your head." Even Pharaoh's servants mocked him for holding out. So Hashem strengthened his heart "**in order to give him a level playing field of free will**." It sounds paradoxical, but "that makes perfect sense": before, it was not fifty-fifty; Hashem strengthens his heart to make it fifty-fifty.

	What "Hashem strengthened Pharaoh's heart" means
The Rambam	Hashem withheld teshuvah after Pharaoh's own wicked choices
The Ramban	Both: repentance withheld, and Hashem restored a level playing field so his choice would be free
Saadia	Hashem kept him physically alive and strong through the plagues; his choices remained entirely his own

Saadia cannot accept either explanation, because both limit free will to some extent. "We're seeing how strong Saadia is."

Category 4: Declaring a Status

Some verses seem to say Hashem *does* something to a person, when He is really **declaring what the person is**.

Saadia's analogy is the judge. We say "the judge vindicated Reuven and condemned Shimon" (as the Torah says of judges, **והצדיקו את הצדיק והרשיעו את הרשע**). We do not mean he caused Reuven to do good and Shimon to do bad. He **declared their status**. A judge who "falsifies" a document has not forged it; he has ruled it a forgery. A money changer who "made this coin good and that coin bad" has not minted them; he has assessed them.

With this in mind you understand:

אם ללצים הוא יליץ ולענוים יתן חן: "He scorns the scorners and gives grace to the humble." Not that Hashem makes scoffers scoff and makes the humble gracious. He **declares** the mockers to be *leitzim* and the humble to be *anavim*. "He's just stating who you are."

אני ה' פתיתי את הנביא ההוא: "I, Hashem, have enticed that prophet." Not that Hashem seduced him into false prophecy. He declared him a false prophet, one who had chosen to be one.

אכן השא השאת לעם הזה ולירושלם לאמר שלום יהיה לכם: "You have surely deceived this people," saying you will have peace." Not that Hashem made the false prophets deceive them. When destruction came, Hashem made it clear that they were false prophets; He passed judgment on them.

למה תתענו ה' מדרכיך: "Why, Hashem, do You make us stray from Your ways?" It means: do not give us the status of strayers. Have mercy, forgive us, "and let us be good people in Your eyes again."

Category 5: Asking Hashem to Turn Our Hearts

Verses like "bring me back to You" and "turn my heart to Your commandments" sound as though we are asking Hashem to **force** us to be good. "How can you ask Hashem to make you be good? You have to choose to be good."

Saadia: these are requests for **atonement**. If You forgive me and give me some credit, You will encourage me to do the right thing and do teshuvah. If You do not forgive me, I will give up hope and sin. Hashem turns my heart **indirectly**: "You're going to turn my heart to You by forgiving me." The turning is still my choice.

Category 6: How We Were Created

"It's very straightforward this, and everyone agrees." Some verses describe how Hashem **made** us, and people mistake them for His ongoing control.

ומה' מענה לשון (Mishlei 16:1), "from Hashem is the answer of the tongue." People think Hashem puts the words in my mouth. No: Hashem gave me a tongue, teeth, a mouth and a heart to think with. "Now I have to use that tongue and that mouth and that heart to make my own choices." The same applies to how we use our eyes and our hearts.

Category 7: "The Heart of a King" as an Exaggeration

"Seven is, again, very difficult to accept."

פלגי מים לב מלך ביד ה' על כל אשר יחפץ יטנו (Mishlei 21:1)

Like channels of water is the heart of a king in the hand of Hashem; He directs it wherever He wishes.

The simple reading, given by the **Ibn Ezra** and the majority: just as one channels water, Hashem directs the heart of a king wherever He wants. Kings receive special direction from Hashem.

Saadia reads it the other way round: just as a person can channel water wherever he likes, **so the king can channel his own heart and decisions wherever he wants**. Why mention a king? It is an **exaggeration** to bring out how strong free will is: even the king, with all his power, chooses freely, and certainly the rest of us do. He gives the same interpretation in his commentary on Mishlei.

"The problem is, what does he do with the words, *in the hand of Hashem*? I don't know the answer to that. I don't understand." The Ibn Ezra does not accept Saadia's reading. On the simple reading, the answer to the free will question has to be what the class discussed a couple of weeks earlier: in great matters affecting huge numbers of people, as kings do, Hashem sometimes intervenes "for the greater sake of humanity." Saadia cannot accept even that, "so he turns it on its head."

Category 8: Hashem Acts, and the Person Then Chooses

When Hashem does something new and the person then chooses to act, the verse may attribute the action to Hashem. There are three aspects.

8a: Salvation or strength

Hashem saves someone or strengthens him, and he then does something good or bad. The verse says Hashem did it, because He did it **indirectly**, by keeping the person alive and able.

ויער אלהי ישראל את רוח פול מלך אשור: Hashem "stirred the spirit" of Pul, king of Ashur, who exiled the two and a half tribes. It does not mean Pul had no free choice. Hashem gave him strength and kept him alive, and Pul decided to exile them.

העיר ה' את רוח כורש: Hashem "stirred the spirit" of Koresh, king of Persia, to build the Temple. Hashem gave him the financial ability, the encouragement and the strength; Koresh chose to build it.

8b: Clarity of mind

Prayers such as "show me Your way," "guide me in Your laws," "turn my eyes from seeing falsehood," and "the hand of God was on Yehudah to give them one heart" sound like requests to be compelled. "What kind of prayer is that?" They mean: Hashem, **give me clarity of mind**, serenity, tranquillity and understanding, a state of mindfulness in which I am able to serve You and keep Your mitzvot. I still choose the path.

8c: A miracle that inspires

Hashem does a miracle; people are awakened by it and choose to do right. It looks as if Hashem compelled them. He did not; they were encouraged.

Eliyahu on Har HaKarmel, at the contest with the prophets of Baal (Melachim I 18:37):

ענני ה' ענני וידעו העם הזה כי אתה ה' האלהים ואתה הסבת את לבם אחרנית

On the usual reading, "You have turned their hearts back," Hashem is turning their hearts, which sounds like compulsion. "Again a very unique interpretation": **Saadia adds the letter *heh*** before *achoranit*, reading it as an adjective: **their backward hearts**. Their hearts are now turned away from You; by answering my sacrifice in place of the Baal sacrifice, You will turn their backward hearts. The miracle encourages them, they choose, and it is described as if Hashem turned them. "Saadia is willing to add in a letter here to take away the problem of free will."

Similarly **ואת רוחי אתן בקרבכם ועשיתי את אשר בחקי תלכו**, "I will put My spirit within you and cause you to walk in My statutes": not that Hashem will force us, but that by showing us wonders He will make us want to choose the right thing.

A Ninth Key: The Order of the Verses

Saadia ends with "one more thing": sometimes **the order of the verses** misleads us, and a verse must be read as continuing an earlier one.

Tehillim 34, said every Shabbat:

עיני ה' אל צדיקים ואזניו אל שועתם. פני ה' בעשי רע להכרית מארץ זכרם. צעקו וה' שמע ומכל צרותם הצילם.

Having said that Hashem's face is set against the wicked to cut them off, the next verse says "they cried out and Hashem heard and saved them from all their troubles." The "they" refers back two verses, to the righteous. Many Rishonim read it this way, and so does Saadia.

The case that matters for free will is **David's psalm after Batsheva** (Tehillim 51):

לך לבדך חטאתי והרע בעיניך עשיתי, למען תצדק בדברך תזכה בשפטך

Read straight on, it sounds as if David sinned *in order that* Hashem's decree would be proved right, as though David were compelled. No: "so that You will be justified in Your words" goes back to the earlier request, **הרבה כבסני מעוני**, "wash me thoroughly from my iniquity," whiten me like snow. Forgive me, so that You will be proved right in Your word that whoever does teshuvah is received back.

"So this is really a ninth category," the Rabbi said, "he calls them eight, but really it's nine keys."

Saadia concludes: with these categories I have removed all your questions. We have no claim that Hashem forces us to do good or bad. "Are we wiser than the Almighty? Certainly not."

Summary: Saadia's Keys to Verses That Seem to Deny Free Will

#	Key	Example
1	A **warning**, described as a prevention	"I withheld you from sinning" (Avimelech)
2	Hashem takes away **physical** benefits; repentance is harder but still possible	"Make the heart of this people fat"
3	Hashem gives **physical strength to survive** so a person can go on choosing	"Hashem strengthened Pharaoh's heart"; Sichon
4	Hashem **declares a status**	"He scorns the scorners"; "I enticed that prophet"
5	We ask for **forgiveness**, which encourages us to return	"Turn my heart to Your commandments"
6	A description of **how we were created**	"From Hashem is the answer of the tongue"
7	An **exaggeration**: even the king chooses freely	"The heart of a king is like channels of water"
8a	Hashem gives **salvation or strength**, then the person acts	Pul; Koresh
8b	Hashem gives **clarity of mind**	"Show me Your way"
8c	Hashem does a **miracle** that inspires a choice	Eliyahu: "their backward hearts"
9	Read the verse as continuing an **earlier verse**	Tehillim 34; Tehillim 51

"What comes out from this, as I hope you've recognised and appreciate now, is how strict Saadia is with free will. He's willing to take pesukim and really reinterpret them from the standard way, at least what we call the standard way, to uphold his really firm understanding of complete free will."

The Rabbi admitted he had rushed the last part: "We could have spent much longer on this."

Where the Book Goes Next

With six chapters, the fourth essay is complete. The Rabbi placed it in the book's journey:

- **Essay 1:** the universe and its creation.
- **Essay 2:** Hashem and His unity.
- **Essay 3:** revelation, prophecy, the Torah and the mitzvot in the broad sense.
- **Essay 4:** free will.
- **Essay 5 (from January):** the **merits and demerits**, going into the details of the mitzvot and *aveirot* of the Torah.

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